

possibility that the foreskin can contribute significantly to sexual enjoyment, is that not a cogent reason for rethinking our motives for this ritual procedure?

The Case Against Circumcision

History shows that the arguments in favor of circumcision are questionable. At the beginning of this century, one of the reasons given for circumcision was to decrease masturbation, which was thought to lead to insanity and other "morbid" conditions. We now know that circumcision does not prevent masturbation, nor does masturbation lead to insanity.

More recently, circumcision was promoted as a means of preventing cervical cancer in the man's sexual partners; this notion has been proved incorrect.⁴ The current excuses are that failure to remove the foreskin may contribute to urinary tract infections and penile cancer, but neither of these contentions has been proved. Performing 100 mutilative surgeries to possibly prevent one treatable urinary tract infection is not valid preventive medicine—it is just another excuse. Penile cancer occurs in older men at a rate of approximately 1 per 100,000. The idea of performing 100,000 mutilating procedures on newborns to possibly prevent cancer in one elderly man is absurd. Applying this type of reasoning to women would seem to lead to the conclusion that breast cancer should be prevented by removing the breasts at puberty.

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"Not only does circumcision
interfere with penile
development, but it requires
that the surgeon tear the skin
from the sensitive glans to
permit removal."

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One thousand years ago, the Jewish sage Maimonides said that the effect of circumcision was "to limit sexual intercourse, and to weaken the organ of generation as far as possible, and thus cause man to be moderate...for there is no doubt that circumcision weakens the power of sexual excitement, and sometimes lessens the natural enjoyment; the organ necessarily becomes weak

when...deprived of its covering from the beginning. Our sages say distinctly: it is hard for a woman, with whom an uncircumcised [man] had sexual intercourse, to separate from him."⁵

Infants are routinely circumcised without anesthesia. In the past few years, scientific papers have demonstrated that infants' responses to pain are similar to those of adults, indicating that babies do indeed experience pain.⁶ This is supported by the fact that the quality of an infant's cry is appallingly different at circumcision.

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Who has the right to order or perform such surgery on a newborn infant? I contend that no one does—not even a physician or the parents—especially as there is no proven medical reason to do so, and the procedure may even be harmful. It can always be performed in adulthood for men who desire it, with fully informed consent.

I believe that physicians who continue to perform routine circumcision are not only harming infants but are also harming the integrity of the medical profession. It is hard to accept that these physicians—most of whom have been circumcised themselves—are using their medical licenses to mutilate others. This is tragedy perpetuating itself.

TFP

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